

can be easily applied to agricultural practices anywhere in the world. The challenges that we have here in the Indian market are something that can help us create agritech solutions for the entire world," says Srivatsa Srenivasarao, co-founder, TraceX Technologies.

A report released by Nasscom in 2019 states that as compared to five global agritech companies that came to India recently, 25 Indian agritech startups have ventured into global markets.

The opportunity

A recent report by Maple Capital Advisors points out that over 500 active agritech startups are operating in India. The same report mentions that the advisory firm is expecting the total investments in the agritech sector to exceed 500 million dollars in the next two years. It is to be noted here that the sector has raised more than 450 million dollars during the last few years. The amount raised in 2019 was 244.59 million dollars. The government of India has also announced the commissioning of a dedicated cell for agri startups.

If Pankaj Karna, MD, Maple Capital Advisors, is to be believed, the golden age of Indian agriculture may well have just begun. He, in the same report, said, "The golden age of Indian agriculture may well have just begun, and it is backed by unparalleled digital access to farmers, overarching reforms and government support."

Karna continued, "The farmer as a consumer and producer is now being empowered by access to information, inputs, farm to fork linkages and financing support. We expect continued investment momentum, especially on the back of significant reforms and digital inclusion."

Another report on agritech startups states that every ninth agritech startup in the world is from India. Ninjacart, an India-based agritech startup, has raised 165 million dollars of funding so far. In fact, the top five agritech startups in India have raised a total of 89 million dollars in the year 2018 alone.

"The agriculture systems in America and Europe have been designed to serve large landlords. India now has the opportunity to be the laboratory for designing agritech for the rest of

the world," says Reihem Roy, partner, Omnivore.

In India, the average farm size, as per the Agriculture Census of India, is 1.08 hectares.

"We need to create and offer solutions to farmers worldwide. The ideal farmers to reach out with these solutions will be the farmers that look like the Indian farmers. South Asia, South East Asia, and Sub-Saharan Africa are good markets to offer solutions," adds Roy.

The recent measures announced by the government of India, which include agri infra fund of hundred thousand rupees and two hundred thousand rupees credit boost to 25 million under Kisan Credit Card Scheme among others, are expected to strengthen infrastructure logistics and capacity building in the agricultural sector to increase farmer's income in the twenty to thirty per cent bracket.

Maple Advisor's report suggests that this will further pave the path for bigger changes and increased private sector participation in the food chain from farm to fork in all elements—marketplaces, cold chains, warehouses, etc.

The small farmer: India's big opportunity

In India, the smallholder farmers (those owning less than 2.0 hectare of farmland) comprise 78 per cent of the country's farmers. However, they own only 33 per cent of the total cultivated land and are still able to produce 41 per cent of the country's food grains. These facts, sourced from the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations (FAO), are more than proof that agritech solutions originating in India will have to focus on small farmers to be able to scale.

To add some more facts sourced from FAO, smallholder farmer families constitute more than half of India's population, and as the national population increases, so does the number of small-holdings.

"When you look at smallholders and analyse properly, you always find out that challenges lead to opportunities. The best agritech solutions for smallholder farmers, in my view, will be something that can bring the smallholder farmers together. Because



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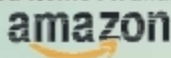
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